

Living Savior Lutheran Church

May 2021 Newsletter

PASTOR'S MESSAGE



In a daily prayer book by John Ballie, ***a Diary of Private Prayer***, Dr. Ballie lists reasons he has for praising and worshiping God. And one phrase he uses says that he gives thanks *"for the great and mysterious opportunity of my life...."*

"For the great and mysterious opportunity of my life..." That is an interesting way to describe our lives! Have you ever thought of your life like that? As a "great and mysterious opportunity." You are alive now. You are you right now on this planet in this century. You have only been given this time, this life. It **IS** a "great and mysterious opportunity" that you will never have again. What are you doing with it? Are you making the most of it? Are you making this opportunity count?

In Isaiah 5, the prophet Isaiah comes singing a song through the streets, a love song, a song about a man and his vineyard. It was love at first sight...this fertile hill that beckoned to him to plant there. So he did. He dug the soil; he cleared the stones; he planted the very finest vines. He even built a stonewall around it to keep out the animals, and even added-a tower in which to stand watch over it, dug a pit in which to tread the grapes ... but every grape was sour!

Isaiah is singing this song about his love that has not been returned by his the one He loves. Isaiah sings to share his pain and get a judgment from the people about what should be done. Lovingly nurtured, watered, fertilized, bathed in the light of God's love, protection and cared for so long ...but so little fruit for the effort ...so little return for the investment...just some sour grapes ...so

many people squandering “the *great and mysterious opportunity of their lives...*”

And what about us? God has invested so much in us too – to give us this “great and mysterious opportunity” to bear fruit. We need to be reminded always what a blessing it is that Jesus died for our forgiveness and rose for our justification.

This God of ours is stubborn. He is stubborn with His grace and mercy. He just won't let go of us – even when we have turned our backs on Him. But God continues to keep after us with grace and mercy. In the fullness of time, at just the right moment in history a few thousand years ago, He sent His beloved Son, and they killed Him too, nailing Him to the cross.

He has planted and protected is Church as a vineyard. He sends us prophets, apostles, and evangelists to preach in the Holy Scriptures. He sends His gifts and teaches us to live as the free, forgiven children of God. He gives us new life in the water of Baptism. We are reconciled with God and with each other in the forgiveness of our sins.

So the challenge is before each of us as Christians; together as a church: What kind of grapes shall we produce? How shall we respond to the God's stubborn grace and mercy? Are we making the most of “*great and mysterious opportunity of your life ...*”? We have a stewardship responsibility to use his gifts wisely and faithfully. And God gives his gifts in the hope of finding a harvest of fruit - trust in him and love for one another.

Therefore, as a church — as a Christian, let us thank God “*For the great and mysterious opportunity of my life...*”

God's peace this month!
Pastor Andrew C. Lissy

